

Wage Wars The Sixth CPC is one of the most contentious in recent memory

Mar 23, 08	Mar 27, 08	Aug 23, 08	Sep 08	Oct 11, 08	Jan 1, 09
Sixth Central Pay Commission report submitted	Service chiefs take grievances to A.K. Antony; a committee set up	Committee files report; Govt directs 6th CPC implementation	Services do not implement CPC; a GoM convened	Armed forces revise scale for all except lieutenant colonels	PMO puts lieutenant colonels in PB-4; halts deputations

wants to halt lieutenant colonels deputations because of the knotty issue of their altered parity vis-à-vis their civilian counterparts in these organisations. An accelerated promotion policy implemented to keep a younger age profile means an army officer can reach the rank of lieutenant colonel in 14 years whereas his counterpart in the paramilitary forces will reach its equivalent rank only after 20 years which could create protocol issues.

This order poses a peculiar set of problems for the forces who have asked for the PMO directive to be withdrawn. "Due to the Government order, in one stroke, these vacancies on deputation have become unavailable to the Services. Retaining such officers in units will lead to man management problems and thus reduce their combat worthiness," said Vice Admiral D.K. Dewan, chairman of the Principal Personnel Officers Committee (PPOC) to Defence Secretary Vijay Singh in a letter dated January 14. With the PMO's directive held in abeyance, the result is a stand-off. And lieutenant colonels

continue to be paid according to the old PB-3 scales. Even if the Government takes a decision, one way or the other, it will take another month to draw up the army instructions and at least three more months to implement them.

"It is absurd to hold 22,000 officers hostage for the sake of 2,000 deputations," says Major General Surjit Singh (retired), a member of the fourth and fifth Pay Commission.

The problem actually began with the sixth CPC clubbing all government officers into four running pay bands which the armed forces say has rocked the boat of parity and status which in turn are governed by the basic pay given to an officer.

The current stand-off is symptomatic of the widening gulf between the armed forces and the Government, particularly the civilian bureaucracy. It can be seen from the choice of curious terminology in the PMO directive—dividing the lieutenant colonels into two categories: combat and ready-to-combat, evidently to establish that officers on deputation do not perform combat duties. In reality, there is no such distinction because these officers are sent into combat units like the NSG, Assam Rifles and covert units like the Special Frontier Force. "Anomalies in the Pay Commission recommendations pointed out by the armed forces do not appear to have been handled with due care by the civilian bureaucracy. A civil-military divide does not augur well for national security in these difficult times," says Brigadier Gurmeet Kanwal (retired), director of the Centre for Land Warfare Studies.

There are also problems of an

officer shortage. The services say they cannot spare 2,100 majors and colonels for deputation which the PMO's letter recommends as substitutes. Majors (six to 12 years of service) are needed to lead companies (around 200 men) in counter-insurgency operations and the army is already facing a shortfall of young officers. Colonels and their equivalent (navy captains and air force group captains) on the other hand are still more valuable as they command battalions and warships. Lieutenant colonels are the most numerous simply because all officers are automatically promoted to this rank. Only 40 per cent become full colonels. The armed forces are unable to accommodate lieutenant colonels who are not promoted because of problems like senior officers serving under them. Hence, each year, the services send out nearly 2,100 lieutenant colonel equivalent officers but at the request of other organisations.

"They bring nearly 15 years of military experience to organisations like the Assam Rifles and NSG. Majors are too young and besides no unit would like to be denuded of young officers," says a senior army official.

It is organisations like the National Cadet Corps who draw nearly 1,000 army officers and the Assam Rifles and NSG who absorb nearly 100 lieutenant colonels each year and use them for internal security duties, who will be affected most by the stoppage of lieutenant colonel deputations. Organisations like the DGQA, DRDO and ordnance factories where lieutenant colonels assist in joint research, development and production could also bear the brunt of this directive. For the moment, however, it is the lieutenant colonels who are bearing the brunt of this impasse. ■

2,100 lieutenant colonels are sent to various government organisations

Assam Rifles

